



LISTEN TO OUR
PODCAST

S. Dipak Ragav

dipak.ragav@thehindu.co.in

India has undoubtedly been among the best one-day international sides in the last decade. Before March 9, 2025, the Men in Blue had played 37 games in ICC ODI competitions (World Cups and Champions Trophy) and won 31.

Unfortunately, despite such a consistent record, the team had no silverware in its cupboard to show, as four of those losses came in the knockout stages. There were two semifinal exits in World Cups (2015, 2019) and two heartbreaks in finals — one in the 2017 Champions Trophy against arch-rival Pakistan and, more recently, the 2023 World Cup (vs. Australia).

However, in sport, as in any other walk of life, if one consistently persists at a task with sincerity, the rewards come sooner rather than later.

For India, that moment arrived on the second Sunday of March at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium when Ravindra Jadeja pulled New Zealand pacer Will O'Rourke through the leg-side to finally ensure India got its hands on an ICC one-day title, sealing a memorable four-wicket win in the summit clash of the ICC Champions Trophy. It was the perfect bookend to one of the finest tournament campaigns in recent times.

Heading into the competition, India was the odds-on favourite for the title. Over three weeks, it lived up to that status and, more importantly, in style, by remaining unbeaten.

The key to India's remarkable run lay in its precise plans and preparations for the tournament.

The event's hybrid model meant India was based in Dubai for all its matches, including the semifinal and final, while other teams shuttled between host Pakistan and the UAE.

There had been much discussion about India's perceived advantage, but it was what everyone had signed up for. However, there is no denying that being based at a single venue helps players acclimatise to the conditions. Four pitches were used for five games, and even if each played slightly differently, the overall nature

of the surface was slow.

Considering the venue had been used for the T20 before the event, India selected five spin options, of which only two were frontline spinners: Kuldeep Yadav and Varun Chakaravathy, a last-minute inclusion in the squad.

That the other spinners, Ravindra Jadeja, Axar Patel and Washington Sundar, were genuine all-rounders showcased the strength of this Indian side. The decision to back the team's spin riches proved to be a masterstroke.

After starting with a conventional attack of two pacers and three spinners in the first two outings against Bangladesh and Pakistan, Varun replaced seamer Harshit Rana against the Black Caps in a dead-rubber league game. He made an immediate impact, scalping a five-wicket haul in only his second ODI.

The decision proved to be a blessing in disguise as it gave the management the confidence to play four spinners from then on, with Mohammed Shami as the only frontline pacer in the last three games. The weather in the Arabian Peninsula had been pleasant, and there was no dew in the evening, which meant that the toss was not a factor.

India's formula for success was similar across all five games, four of which were won while chasing, and a discernible pattern emerged.



Since Rohit Sharma took over as captain, India has refashioned its approach to the limited-overs format, shunning conservatism and embracing a hard-nosed approach that blends flamboyance with pragmatism.